The Day I Ate Whatever I Wanted

By Elizabeth Berg

Jonetta Reed, a 27-year-old graduate student at Cleveland State University explains . . . "If I could sum it up in one sentence: There's more to me than meets the eye. And I think that goes for pretty much everyone, including every person who's overweight. It's not this whole thing where you just eat too much and you have no self-control and you don't exercise. I do exercise. I do try to control my portions. We're not like Homer Simpson, just eating a thousand hamburgers. It's not like that. We're really great people to be friends with and go out with and have relationships with, so don't just count us out because we're fat."

SOURCE OF THIS QUOTE: http://www.cleveland.com/fighting-fat/index.ssf/2010/04/the_heavy_burden_of_being_heavy_as_told_by_5_who_have_struggled.html

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INTRODUCTION

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I began at Dunkin' Donuts. I hadn't gone there since I started Weight Watchers a year ago because I had to lose weight; my doctor *made* me go.

Weight Watchers is a good organization, I mean it does actually work if you do the program and they try really hard to make you like you, which as you may know is a problem a lot of fat people have, they have low self-esteem. Skinny people look at fat people with disgust and have visions of them stretched out on fuchsia-colored silk sofas snarfing down Cool Ranch Doritoes and Ben and Jerry's Chunky Monkey, but it isn't like that. What it is, is eating and eating with your shoulders hunched and your head down to scratch that itch that won't get scratched, and you have so much shame when you gobble things down you hardly even taste them. You start with I want and you end with I want, only now you have even more weight added to what is already too much and don't think we don't know it all, all, all the time.

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But anyway, I went to my Weight Watchers meeting one day, and in addition to the usual annoying emaciated people who have no business there, there were two new members who absolutely blew my mind. Both of them on the same day. One was an old woman on oxygen with a walker taking about a thousand hours to get to the scales, and she was not to my eye fat at all. The other was a blind woman. Here is my question: When that blind woman looks into her mirror, what does she see? And anyway, she, too, had no visible blubber. I mean, I just walked out. I said to myself, No. Today, on account of those two women, on behalf of those two women, I am going to eat anything I want from now until midnight. And I drove right over to Dunkin' Donuts [and] got coffee, heavy cream. "Anything else?" the counter person asked. She was about thirty years old, beautiful long black hair tied back in a ponytail under her Dunkin' Donuts hat and a really big caboose. What can you do? You'd have to be a weird person not to gain a lot of weight if you worked at D.D. But anyway, [her] fat looked good, truly, every now and then you see a

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person who wears fat well, it is that tight fat and just really looks kind of delicious and also their attitude is just great, like in your face: I'm fat . . . so what . . . get over your sanctimonious self. Anyway, after [she] said, "Anything else?" I said, "Oh yes, I want some donuts." I cannot tell you how swell that felt.

"How many donuts?" And I said, "Just get a big box, please, but maybe we won't quite fill it." So she got out a big Dunkin' Donuts box and I just started salivating, like that experiment dog. "Okay. A bow tie, a chocolate-frosted cake, a Key lime, a powdered cake, a Boston Kreme, a lemon bark, a maple-frosted, a coffee roll, a maple-frosted coffee roll, a cranberry muffin, a bagel and cream cheese and butter, too, on the bagel, and a plain Dunkin donut." And then before she tallied it up I handed her a fifty and said just keep the change and walked out. My back was feeling kind of hypervisible, like I was walking away really cool from a crime scene where I'd been the criminal. My heart was racing and my mood level had shot way, way up.

I got in my car and then I looked around and

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there was no one so I ran my tongue along every single surface of every single donut. Then I sucked the filling out of the Boston Kreme. I dipped the powdered cake in the coffee and had one bit; ditto the chocolate-frosted. I went on in this manner until I would say about a third of the donuts were gone. And then I am sorry to say I threw the rest away.

I was pretty full, so I went for a walk in a park to make room for lunch. It was a nice day and there were joggers and lots of dogs. Once was a bulldog puppy, which, please, has cornered the market on cuteness. The owner was this very thin woman who looked sort of bitchy, which, think about it, most very thing women do – even when they smile, it's like grimacing. Fat people are often miserable, too, but at least they look jolly even though it's really mostly them apologizing, like "Sorry, sorry, sorry I'm taking up so much room," "Sorry I'm offending your idea of bodily aesthetics," "Sorry I'm clogging my arteries and giving the thumbs-up to diabetes." And spilling over airline seats, which, come on, even for skinny people those seats are ridiculous.

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Metal girdles!

I decided I'd go for lunch to this café I know where the butter is real and the syrup is real and the waitresses do not in any way judge what you order. I ordered a bacon cheeseburger, fries, and a chocolate malted, and I loaded up the fries with salt and made a neat pile of catsup. When the waitress asked, "Will there be anything else?" I almost ordered two over easy with hash browns because I just wanted one bit of the potatoes mixed with yolk, but no, that would be been too much wastefulness in one day.

But. Because this was a day purposefully given over to gluttony and greed, I walked over to a bookstore, where I looked at cookbooks. You may think, Right, she looked at dessert books, but that's where you would be wrong. Because guess what? Vegetarian. And some Mediterranean and Indian. And okay, then I found this one? The cake doctor? Which so made me in the mood for a piece of cake. So I went and got that at another café, but I could only fit in half.

By now I was feeling the shame but also defiance.

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Like here, I'm carrying the banner for all of you who cut off a little piece wanting a big one, who spend a good third of your waking hours feeling bad about your desires, who infect those with whom you work and live with your judgments and pronouncements, you on the program who tally points all day long, every day, let's see, 7 for breakfast, I'm going to need only 3 or 4 for lunch, what can I have for so little? Oh, I know. Broth and a salad with very little dressing. And broth is good! Yea! So chicken! That's what we tell ourselves, we who cannot eat air without gaining, we who eat the asparagus longing for the potatoes au gratin, for the fettuccine Alfredo, for the pecan pit. And if you're one of those who doesn't stop right there. You are not invited to the rest of this story. . . . [I thought so].

Okay. Dinner. I was going to have steak and mushrooms and a loaded backed potato and Caesar salad . . . and apple crisp and crumb-topped cherry pie. And a baguette with European butter. You can imagine it, can't you? The mushrooms sautéed in butter lying seductively over the steak. The potato, buried under

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butter, bacon, green onion, and sour cream. The two desserts sitting side by side, can you see them? I knew after the day was over I'd have to go back to the plan, go back and confess at my meeting. Which is okay, it's fine, you can say anything at a meeting. Once someone said she had cheesecake left in her refrigerator from a family dinner and everyone was saying, "Oh, my God, get rid of it, give it away." Someone else said, "just throw it away." And this other woman said, "Well, I'm sort of embarrassed to admit this but I have actually taken food out of my garbage and now I've learned that I have to pour water on it before I throw it away."

I myself put coffee grounds over food I throw away, that'll do it. . . . I ate the dinner, the whole thing, just like I said. And then I took a wooden mallet and I bet my scale. I wanted springs to pop out like they might in a cartoon, but all that happened was it didn't work anymore and it had a few dents. Still.

The next day I went to a Weight Watchers meeting. . . . I never confessed. I got weighed and I was four pounds up and they were just like, "Well, that

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happens," and I bought another scale and that night I had turkey burgers for dinner. 7 points and actually very good and I had spinach and a two-point ice cream thing. And I drank lots of water.

I have to tell you this funny story about water and Weight Watchers that our leader told us. She said she was telling a new member the rules and she guessed she talked too fast. She told the woman to be sure to drink six to eight glasses of water a day. And the woman came back the next week saying, "I did everything you said, but I just can't drink sixty-eight classes of water a day." Imagine her at the sink, upending yet another glass of water, wide-eyed and discouraged: This program is hard!

I would like to end this by saying that it felt really good to cheat all day, to eat whatever I wanted. But it didn't. All that happened was that I felt hollow-eyed. I felt like one time when I was a little girl and I sat on the porch steps one summer evening with my dad. I was already really chubby and he was a very fat man with pretty blue eyes. A couple of times I was with him

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when people made jokes about how fat he was. He would laugh like he thought it was funny and his belly would shake, it went up and down when it shook, but their remarks hurt him, I could see it – he registered pain in those instances by one quick jerk of his right eyelid. But that night he took my hand and I moved closer to him. I wished someone could [really] see.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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